

What could the school do differently?

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- Without realistic expectations that lead to...

- Describe the contributions of any three Indians who fought against inequality in about 80 words.
- Describe the role of the government in ensuring equality in not more than 100 words.
- Explain the role of individuals in promoting equality.

G. HOTS – Think and answer.

- Describe any one law or scheme promoting equality that is implemented in a proper manner in your community and one that is not implemented properly in about 80 words.
- Equality in India has been a long struggle. Do you think inequality still exists in India? Justify your answer with examples.
- In your notebook, write the steps that you would take in the following situations:
 - You see your partner not behaving properly with one of your classmates because she comes from a village.
 - When you visit your friend's house, his mother tells him not to enter the kitchen as it is a girl's job to cook.
 - Your younger sister does not treat poor people with respect whenever you go out with her.

H. Competency-based questions

- In which of the situations below do you think someone is not being treated equally? Give reasons to support your answer.
 - Ullas was rejected in a job interview because he did not have the required qualifications.
 - Radhika was not allowed to speak at the annual day function of the company because she is a woman.
 - A bus driver allows only the so-called upper caste people to ride his bus.
- A school is organising its sports day in the coming month. Selections are going on for cricket, basketball, football, swimming, and different types of races. Every student is allowed to participate in the selection round. Those who perform well will get selected to participate in the sports day. Read the conversation between two students from this school and answer the questions that follow.

Keerthi: I am so excited about the selection round. I have practised so hard. I am sure I will make it to the football team.

Afrin: I wish they had something for me too. How can I get selected for any of these games while sitting in a wheelchair?

 - Do you think the school is practising equality as fair treatment or as equal treatment? Why do you think so?
 - What could the school do differently to ensure Afrin feels included in the sports day?

REFLECTIONS

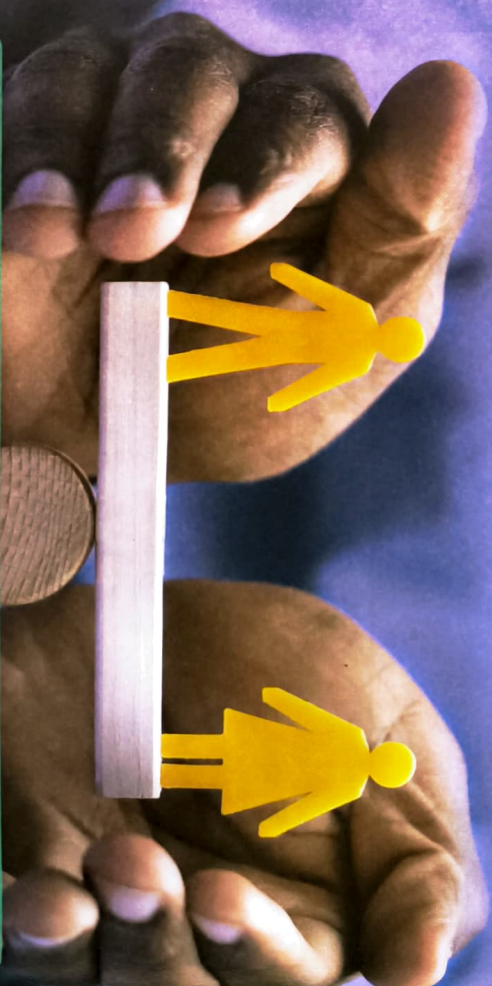
- What is your opinion about the inequalities that you see around you?
- What did you enjoy learning the most in this chapter?
- Which part of the chapter did you find the most difficult to understand? Did you use any special methods to study these difficult parts?



Our Cultural Heritage and Knowledge Traditions

13. Understanding Gender

5/8/26



IN THIS CHAPTER, YOU WILL ...

- Understand gender as a social construct and think about some of the gender stereotypes in our society.
- Learn about the prevailing inequalities in our society due to gender.
- Understand the role of government and us as individuals in maintaining gender equality.

CONNECTIONS TO OUR LIFE

- Many of us grow up in an environment where there are different expectations from boys and girls or men and women.
- Without realising, we carry forward these expectations that lead to biases and inequalities.

BIG IDEA

Gender refers to the different ways in which society expects men and women to behave. These expectations can lead to inequality. We must recognise and break free from these expectations to create a more equal world.



LET'S BEGIN

Many of us would have come across statements such as 'Boys do not cry', 'Cricket is not a game for girls', and 'A girl must know how to cook'. These statements help us understand how society expects different things from boys and girls or men and women. Let us do an activity to understand this better.

ACTIVITY

Lakshmi is 10 years old. She has been invited to the birthday party of her classmate, Jacob, a 10-year-old boy who is deeply interested in classical music and dance. Lakshmi wants to gift her friend a pair of ghungroos because she thinks Jacob would be an excellent Kathak dancer. However, Lakshmi's amma laughs the idea away. She suggests that Lakshmi should buy a cricket bat or a toy racing car for him.

Discuss the following questions in your group.

- Why do you think Lakshmi's amma felt that a cricket bat or a toy racing car would be a better gift for Jacob's?
- Do you think Lakshmi's amma would have made the same suggestion if Lakshmi had gone to the birthday party of a girl? Give reasons for your answer.



We know that unequal treatment of people is known as discrimination. When people are treated differently or unequally because of their gender, it is known as **gender discrimination**.

In this chapter, we will learn about the meaning of gender and the factors that cause gender inequality. We will also think about the effects that gender discrimination can have on us and on society. As we do this, we will connect these new learnings to what we learned in the last chapter on equality and the role of laws in allowing people to live peacefully and happily in a society. This will help us understand the importance of gender equality and the ways in which we can promote it.

13.1 MEANING OF GENDER



Gender refers to the expectations that society has about how boys and girls and men and women must behave and the roles they must play. It is not something that we are born with. It is socially constructed. Therefore, the understanding of gender can be different in different societies. Let us understand this better with the help of an example.

Growing Up as Part of the Khasi Tribe in Meghalaya

A child born in the Khasi tribe in Meghalaya of India takes



their mother's surname. Both the parents play an important role in taking care of the needs of the children. When parents grow old, they often stay with their youngest daughter. The daughters also receive a larger share of their parents' property as compared to the sons.

Growing Up in a Household of Haryana

A child born in a household in Haryana in India takes their father's surname. While the



father is usually the breadwinner of the family, the mother is responsible for taking care of the children. When parents grow old, they often stay with one of their sons. The sons also receive a larger share of their parents' property as compared to the daughters.

The understanding of gender can also change over time. For example, in the olden days, girls were not allowed to go to school because society did not consider it important enough for girls to be educated. Over time, this has changed. Today, every child in our country between the ages of 6 and 14 years has the right to education, irrespective of their gender.

13.2 GENDER INEQUALITY

We just learned how the understanding of gender varies in different societies. In most societies, the roles and responsibilities that men and women are expected to fulfil are not the same. In addition, the roles and responsibilities to be fulfilled by men are considered far more important than the ones women are expected to fulfil. This is known as **gender inequality**. Various factors lead to gender inequality. Let us learn about them.

Stereotypes



A stereotype is a fixed or widely accepted belief about a particular group of people, which may not be true. It often leads to bias towards a person or group of people. Our **preconceived** ideas and opinions on how boys and girls should behave and their roles and responsibilities lead to gender inequality.

For example, a very common stereotype in our society is that men are better at working outside and earning for the family. Therefore, women are expected to take care of household responsibilities. In fact, many societies discourage boys from doing household chores such as cooking or washing dishes, even when they want to do it. Let us look at some more examples of how gender stereotypes affect us right from the time when we are born.

It's a girl!



I got the perfect gift for her – a kitchen set!

But I like to play with toy cars!



It's a boy!



I got the perfect gift for him – a toy car!

But I like to play with dolls!



Eh, wash the utensils and put your brother to sleep.

But I have homework to do!



Are you a girl? What are you doing in the kitchen?



Learn to cook. It will help you.

But I want to be an engineer!



Stop your art work. Do math and science. You have to earn for your family.



I always wanted to be an engineer! Oh, what has my life become!



After 20 years

I am stuck in this job. I wish I could point for a living.



After 20 years

KEYWORDS

preconceived ideas and opinions that are formed on a topic without enough information or experience

THINK

Like women, gender stereotypes impact men too since they are expected to behave in a certain way and take up financial responsibilities. Do you agree? Why or why not?



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But I like to play with dolls!

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I am stuck in this job. I wish I could point for a living.



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preconceived ideas and opinions that are formed on a topic without enough information or experience

THINK

Like women, gender stereotypes impact men too since they are expected to behave in a certain way and take up financial responsibilities. Do you agree? Why or why not?



Scan here to learn about gender inequality

ACTIVITY 2

Observe the images given below and answer the questions that follow.



Ashish's father does not allow him to buy a pink shirt as he thinks boys should not wear pink.



Mohan's neighbour laughs at him when he sees him working in the kitchen.

- (a) Which gender stereotypes do you see in these images?
(b) Do you agree with these stereotypes? Why/Why not?

The more people believe in gender stereotypes, the more they are forced into following these beliefs. Families and schools often strengthen these stereotypes. Read on to find out how.

Family

Families play an important role in our lives. What we see in our families has a lasting impact on us. Very often, families strengthen gender stereotypes by choosing the way children dress up, the kind of clothes they wear, the games they play, and the chores they are expected to do at home.

While families often strengthen existing gender stereotypes, they can also break these stereotypes and help children understand the importance of an equal world. Let us understand this better by reading about two families.

Family A

Sapna and her brother have clear roles and responsibilities at home. While Sapna helps her mother in household chores, her brother is responsible for getting things from the market. Sapna's mother is also teaching her how to cook, while her brother is working on his physical strength by working out with their father.

Family B

Apoorva and her brother are both expected to take care of household chores such as watering the plants, cleaning their rooms, and getting things from the market. On Sundays, they both learn how to cook from their parents. Both of them are encouraged to try out different sports. The rules to be followed at home are the same for both.

COLLABORATE

In your groups, discuss any one gender stereotype that you have seen or experienced yourself. On a sheet of paper, do the following:

- Draw a picture that represents the gender stereotype you discussed.
- Explain how the stereotype affects us.



CONNECT TO LIFE

What are some gender stereotypes that you see in your own family? Have you noticed any gender stereotype that has changed over time in your family?

Family A strengthens gender stereotypes that women must take care of household responsibilities, while men must take care of work outside the house. Family B, on the other hand, breaks gender stereotypes by expecting both the boy and the girl to do household chores as well as work outside the house.

When we see gender stereotypes being broken in our own families, we understand that these stereotypes are only opinions that can be changed.

School

Just like families, schools play an important role in our development. We spend a significant amount of time in school. So, schools can also either strengthen or break gender stereotypes. Let us understand this with examples.

School A

In this school, girls are not encouraged to do sport. The school believes that girls do not have the physical strength needed to excel at tough sports. Thus, the school has no sports team for girls.

School B

In this school, boys and girls are both encouraged to do sport. They have a girls' sports team that plays at the district level, just like the boys' sports team. They also have coaches to train both boys and girls in sports.

KEYWORDS

Skills: things that we can do well

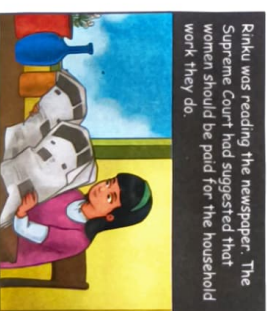
THINK

Do you think boys and girls have different skills and they are born with these skills? Support your thinking with reasons.

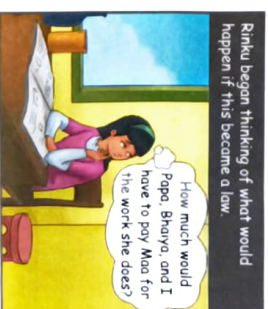
13.3 IMPACT OF GENDER INEQUALITY ON WOMEN

Devaluing the Work Women Do

Gender inequality has a deep impact on the lives of men and women. In some of the earliest human communities, men went out to hunt, while women took care of children and other household responsibilities. Over time, this has resulted in the belief that men are more capable of earning money by working outside the house, while women must take care of household work. As a result, a lot of the work that women are expected to do is unpaid and not considered important.

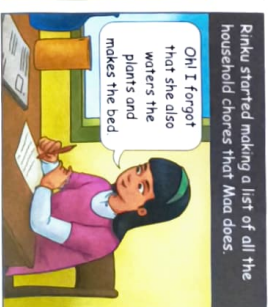


Rinku was reading the newspaper. The Supreme Court had suggested that women should be paid for the household work they do.



Rinku began thinking of what would happen if this became a law.

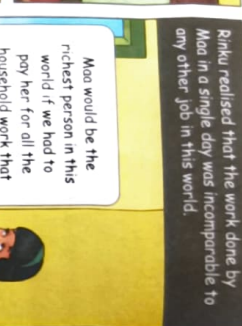
How much would Papa, Bhavya, and I have to pay Maa for the work she does?



Rinku started making a list of all the household chores that Maa does.

Oh! I forgot that she also waters the plants and makes the bed.

on and on and
on and on and
on and on and
on and on and on.



Limited Opportunities for Education

This situation, however, has improved over time: literacy rates among women have increased over the years. Women in the olden days were not allowed to study because their families believed that it would prevent them from learning household work. They kept women's social and economic status low by keeping them uneducated and tied to the house.

Study the graph showing the literacy rates of men and women from 1951 to 2018 and answer the following questions.

1. What does the graph tell us about the literacy levels of women in the last 50 years?
2. Based on your understanding of the graph, write a short report explaining the impact of changing literacy rates on the women of India over time

Sahiba's father and mother are both doctors in a reputed hospital. Their working day usually lasts from 8 to 10 hours. Before going to work, Sahiba's father goes for a morning walk. Her mother cooks breakfast and lunch for the day, sends the children to school, and finishes other household chores with the help of a domestic worker.

What differences do you observe in the daily routines of Sahiba's father and mother? Who will be more tired? Why?

1-0

We know that gender equality is important for individuals to

realise their full potential But is gender equality important only for girls and not for boys? Imagine that you are a boy who loves to paint, dance, or cook. How would you feel if you were forced to give up on your interests and focus only on studying math and science because you need to earn for the family when you grow up? Gender equality is important for all of us.

Gender equality that we see today in our country is the result of the movements for equality that men and women in India have led over the years. Let us learn about this in detail.



Interview two male and two female teachers as part of a survey to find out their routine after work. What do you observe based on the data?

Observe the daily routine of each of your family members. Look for instances where equal opportunity is not given to any member of your family because of their gender. Discuss with your partner how this impacts him/her.

1 In older times, women were denied education and married off at an early age, often to older men. Social evils, such as the *sati* system, were prevalent. Widow remarriage was not allowed. Widows had a very difficult life.



3 Many women social reformers worked for the education of girls.

- Savitribai Phule, along with her husband Jyotirao Phule, founded the first modern Indian girls' school in 1848 in Pune.
- Pandita Ramabai opened Sarada Sadan, where she encouraged widows to get educated and learn a skill that would help them earn money.



Fig 13.3 Savitribai Phule



Fig 13.4 Pandita Ramabai

5 Women demanded legal reforms by protesting publicly and campaigning for their rights. They raised awareness to help victims of violence.



2 Early social reformers played an important role in bringing about social change.

- Raja Rammohun Roy led the movement to abolish *sati* in 1829.
- Ishwar Chandra Vidyasagar supported girls' education. Widow remarriage became legal in 1856 because of his efforts.



Fig 13.1 Raja Rammohun Roy



Fig 13.2 Ishwar Chandra Vidyasagar

4 Slowly, women's movement merged with India's

freedom struggle. Several women participated actively in protests against British rule.



Fig 13.5 Sarojini Naidu, an Indian freedom fighter

5 A major achievement of the women's movement was the emphasis on gender equality in the Indian Constitution. While women were given equal political rights, their social status did not improve much. They continued to suffer from dowry issues, domestic violence, poor health conditions, and lack of educational opportunities.

THINK

The early social reforms were mostly led by men who worked to improve the social status of women. What could be the reason for this?

DID YOU KNOW?

In 1961, the Indian Government passed the Dowry Prohibition Act to prevent the giving and receiving of dowries during marriages and to solve problems caused by dowry practices.



To learn about dowry practices, scan the QR code.

13.6 PROMOTING GENDER EQUALITY

Promoting gender equality is essential to ensure that we progress as a nation and people live happily. Gender equality is a shared responsibility of the government and all individuals. Let us learn about this in detail.

Role of the Government

The government plays an important role in promoting gender equality by

- making and implementing laws and policies that promote gender equality
- creating awareness of the need to create an equal society.

Let us read about some laws and policies that the government has made to promote gender equality.

- 1. Right to Education** – According to this law, every child in India between the ages of 6 and 14 years must get free and compulsory education. This law helps promote gender equality by giving equal educational opportunities to both boys and girls.

- 2. Right to Equality** – The fundamental right to equality is an important measure that prohibits any form of discrimination, including gender discrimination. It also guarantees equal opportunities for employment and equal pay for equal work. We can approach the courts if any of these provisions are violated.

- 3. Reservation for Women in Panchayats** – 33% of seats in panchayats are reserved for women. This policy was introduced to support women leaders so that they can work towards promoting equality in their communities.

- 4. Laws against Dowry and Domestic Violence** – Many women have faced violence due to the evil practice of giving and taking dowry. Recognising the impact of violence on women, the government has passed laws that make dowry and domestic violence punishable.

Role of the Individuals

The government alone cannot help us achieve gender equality. Our role in preventing gender discrimination is equally important. Here are a few steps that we can take to promote gender equality.

- Treat everyone equally, irrespective of their gender.
- Encourage people around us to think about and break the gender stereotypes they come across.
- Be aware and spread awareness about the laws and policies that promote gender equality.

LET'S REVISE

1. Meaning of Gender

- Gender refers to the expectations that society has about how boys and girls and men and women must behave and the roles they must play. It is socially constructed.

2. Gender Inequality

- The roles and responsibilities to be fulfilled by men are considered more important than the ones women are expected to fulfil. This is known as gender inequality.
- School and family can play an important role in strengthening or breaking gender stereotypes.

3. Impact of Gender Inequality on Women

- The work that women do is often considered less important than the work that men do.
- Women get limited access to educational opportunities.
- Unequal division of housework leaves women with no time to relax or focus on themselves.

4. Struggles for Gender Equality

- Social reformers like Raja Rammohun Roy, Ishwar Chandra Vidyasagar, Savitribai Phule, and Pandita Ramabai supported education for girls and worked to promote gender equality.
- During the freedom struggle, women played an important part in fighting against British rule.
- After independence, our Constitution guaranteed equal rights for men and women. However, the social and economic status of women did not improve much.
- Women fought against gender inequality and continue to do so. Many of the laws and provisions that promote gender equality are the result of this fight.

5. Promoting Gender Equality

- Both the government and we, as individuals, play an important role in promoting gender equality.
- The government has made several laws and policies that promote gender equality.
- We must practise gender equality in our everyday lives and encourage others to do the same.

EXERCISES

1. Fill in the blanks.

- Gender is a society construct.
- Gender stereotypes lead to gender discrimination.
- Families can either strengthen or weaken gender stereotypes.
- Veena Ramani opened Sarada Sadan where widows were encouraged to get educated and learn a skill that would help them earn money.
- 33% of seats in reservations are reserved for women.

8. Choose the correct answer.

- Which of the following is NOT an example of a gender stereotype?
 - Boys are naughty, and girls are quiet.
 - Girls cook better food than boys.
 - Both girls and boys can play cricket.
 - Only boys are good at sports.
- Which of the following is an impact of gender inequality on women?
 - Equal opportunities for education
 - Devaluing the work done by women
 - Equal sharing of household work
 - Reservation for Women in Panchayats
- Who led the movement to abolish sati in 1829?
 - Savitribai Phule
 - Raja Rammohun Roy
 - Pandita Ramabai
 - Ishwar Chandra Vidyasagar
- Which right guarantees equal opportunities for employment and equal pay for equal work?
 - Right to Education
 - Right to Freedom
 - Right to Property
 - Right to Equality

- Which of the following is a way in which we can promote gender equality?
 - Follow gender stereotypes
 - Rely solely on government initiatives
 - Treat everyone equally
 - Ignore laws about gender equality

C. Write True or False. Rewrite the false statements correctly in your notebook.

- When people are treated differently or unequally because of their gender, it is known as gender discrimination. True
- Our preconceived ideas and opinions on how boys and girls should behave lead to gender inequality. False
- Widow remarriage became legal in 1856 because of the efforts of Savitribai Phule. False
- Right to Equality promotes gender equality by giving equal educational opportunities to both boys and girls. True
- We should encourage people around us to follow gender stereotypes. False

D. Name the following:

- A social reformer who worked for the abolition of sati Raja Rammohun Roy
- A social reformer who worked to make widow remarriage legal Savitribai Phule
- Two social reformers who established the first Indian school for girls Savitribai Phule and Jyoti Basu
- A woman social reformer who was also a freedom fighter Bagmati Naidu

E. Answer the following questions in brief:

- What do you understand by the term gender equality? Answer in about 20–30 words.
- What are gender stereotypes? How are gender stereotypes strengthened?
- Explain why gender equality is important for us.
- Do you think it is only the government's responsibility to ensure gender equality? Why/why not?
- List any three ways in which we can play a positive role in reducing gender inequality.

F. Answer the following questions in detail:

- Using an example, explain how gender stereotypes lead to gender inequality.
(Hint: Identify a gender stereotype. Think how it leads to different opportunities for boys and girls or men and women.)
- Describe any two factors that lead to gender inequality in not more than 80 words.
- How do women get affected by the unpaid work they do?
- Explain the historical evolution of the women's movement in India in about 100 words.
(Writing tip: Begin with the status of women in India in the past. Explain how this has changed over the years. End with an explanation of the status of women in the present times.)
- Describe any two laws that the government has passed to promote gender equality.

G. HOTS – Think and answer.

- Write a paragraph in about 70–80 words narrating your experience of growing up as a boy or a girl. Describe any incident or occasion when you felt that our society has different expectations from boys and girls.
- List any two positive changes happening in society in recent times that are a result of gender equality.

H. Competency-based questions

- Read the situations below and identify the example of gender inequality. Give reasons to support your answer.
 - The village council only allows wealthy landowners to vote in important decisions.
 - In a town, people of a certain community are not allowed to use the public well.
 - In a village, only boys are allowed to go to school, while girls must stay home to do housework.
- Read the following situation and answer the questions that follow:
In a class, the teacher assigns a group project on researching and creating a presentation about an important historical figure from India. In every group, the teacher assigns the role of group leader to the boys. She also decides that the boys will handle the research and speaking parts of the presentation, while the girls are only given the task of making the posters and slides.
 - Is it fair for the teacher to assign roles based on gender? Why or why not?
 - What could the teacher do differently to make sure all students have equal chances?

REFLECTIONS

- Write any one thing you would do to promote gender equality.
- How will you ensure that you keep doing what you wrote as an answer to the previous question?
- Which topic did you find the most difficult in this chapter? What steps did you take to understand that topic?

ENRICHMENT ACTIVITIES

PROJECT WORK

Gender Roles Presented in Media

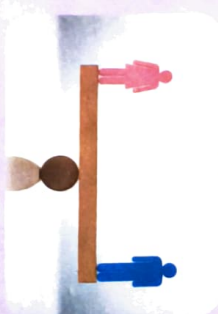
Analyse the portrayal of different genders in any two movies, TV shows, or advertisements and evaluate the messages conveyed about equality.

Step 1: Select two movies, TV shows, or advertisements to analyse.

Step 2: Watch your chosen media carefully and take notes on how male and female characters are portrayed. Focus on their roles, behaviour, and the messages conveyed about gender equality.

Step 3: Compare the portrayals of male and female characters. Look for any stereotypes and assess whether one gender is shown in more powerful or important roles than the other.

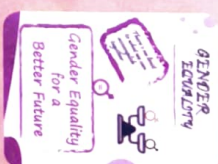
Step 4: Compile your observations and analysis into a report. Discuss the messages about equality and gender that are presented in the media examples. Present your report in class.



CROSS-CURRICULAR CONNECT

Poster on Gender Equality (English and Art)

- Design a poster that promotes gender equality.
- Use powerful slogans, images, and symbols that convey your message clearly and effectively.
- Share your poster in class.



FIELD TRIP

Understanding Economic Equality

- Choose a few public places to visit, such as a supermarket, post office, library, restaurant, or community centre.
- Note how many men and women are working in different roles at each location.
- Pay attention to whether certain jobs are mainly done by men or women.
- Interview one male and one female worker. Ask them about their job, roles and responsibilities, and any challenges they face in their work. Make sure to record your observations and the information gathered from the interviews.
- Discuss your findings in class.



10/6/26,



Governance and Democracy

14. How Does Democracy Work?



IN THIS CHAPTER, YOU WILL ...

- Learn about the different types of elections and how they are conducted in India.
- Learn about the different types of political parties and their importance.

CONNECTIONS TO OUR LIFE

- By voting in elections, we have the power to shape the future of our country.
- Political parties influence the lives of most people. Many of us would be attracted to the ideas put forward by a specific political party.

BIG IDEA

Elections strengthen the system of democracy. Free and fair elections are necessary to ensure that everyone participates in a democracy.

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LET'S BEGIN

ACTIVITY 1

Your teacher received a circular from the principal about a student council that is being formed in the school. This council will make important decisions regarding the different events conducted in the school, such as sports day and annual day, and solve students' issues. It will include representatives from all classes. The principal wants each class to select one representative. In your group, discuss how your class should select the representative. How would you choose the student, and what steps would you follow?

Some of you might have chosen to vote for your class representative and discussed how you would conduct the class election. This is similar to how a democratic government is formed. We know that democracy is one of the most popular forms of government which is made of the people, for the people, and by the people. In a democracy, people take part in decision-making by voting in elections. In this chapter, we will learn about how elections take place.

14.1 VOTING AND ELECTIONS



We often come across situations in our day-to-day lives when we must make decisions. It is much easier to come to a decision on your own and more difficult when a group needs to make a choice.

Voting is a process by which a group of people can decide things fairly when they might not all agree with one particular choice. Voting is an important part of democracy. In a democracy, people use voting to choose their representatives who form the government. The right to vote is called **suffrage** or **franchise**. In India, anyone aged 18 years or older is eligible to vote. This is called **universal adult franchise**.

When a group of people votes, it is called an election. **Elections** are the process through which citizens choose who will represent them in the government and make decisions on their behalf.

The people who want to be elected are called **candidates**. They often run campaigns before elections in which they try to convince voters that they are right for the job. They often make speeches and run advertisements on television and other kinds of media for this.

Elections are an essential feature of democracy for the following reasons:

1. Elections ensure that all sections of society are a part of the decision-making process of the country.



2. Elections strengthen democracy as people have the power to choose who represents them, making representatives accountable to the public.



Fig. 14.1: People casting their votes



Fig. 14.2: A candidate campaigning before elections

KEYWORDS
accountable: required to justify actions or decisions; responsible

Types of Elections in India

Elections are held at regular intervals for the smooth functioning of a democracy. Let us look at the different types of elections conducted in India.

1. General Elections

General elections in India are usually held when the ruling government completes its term of office and a new government must be elected. This usually happens once every five years.

2. Midterm Elections

Midterm elections are held to elect a new government when the ruling government cannot complete its term of five years due to various reasons. Midterm elections happened in India in the years 1996 and 1998.

3. By-Elections

By-elections are held in case an elected representative passes away or resigns from their post before their term ends. This is to make sure that there is a representative to take care of the needs of the people.

14.2 ELECTION COMMISSION OF INDIA

We all know that elections are essential in democracies. But are all elections fair and free?

Though elections are an important feature of democracy, as we saw in the activity given in the communicate box, sometimes cheating can happen. Candidates may misuse money or muscle power to make sure they win an election. Thus, it is necessary to ensure that free and fair elections are held.

In free and fair elections,

1 Anyone who is 18 years of age or older and is eligible to vote must have the opportunity to vote.

2 Everyone should have the liberty and freedom to vote for the candidate of their choice. Their caste, religion, gender, or economic status should not be considered during this.

3 One person should have only one vote.

COMMUNICATE

Your class has decided to hold an election to nominate the student council representative. One of the students who is running is a known bully. When it is your turn to vote, you see that he and his friends are standing near the ballot box and are watching to see who votes for him and who does not. Do you think the election results will be fair? Why or why not? Discuss with your partner.

Every country has its own methods and rules to conduct elections. These methods and rules are in place to ensure that the elections are conducted fairly. Let us do an activity to understand more about this.

ACTIVITY 2

Your school is holding elections at both the class and the whole school level. Discuss the answers to the following questions with your group:

- Who should be responsible for setting the rules for elections to be held to choose school leaders? Who should be the people voting in the school elections?
- Who should be responsible for setting the rules for elections to be held to choose class leaders? Who should be the people voting in the class elections?

Give reasons for your answers.

In India, we have an institution that sets rules for conducting and managing the elections to the central government and the state governments. It is called the **Election Commission of India**.

The Election Commission of India (ECI) is an autonomous body set up under a provision given in the Constitution of India. It is responsible for conducting free and fair elections in India. The ECI is present both at the national and state levels.

The ECI is headed by the Chief Election Commissioner. There are two election commissioners to assist the Chief Election Commissioner. The different roles of the ECI are given below.

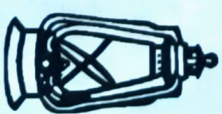
1 It conducts free and fair elections at the national level and the state levels.

2 It provides a set of guidelines called the Model Code of Conduct on how political parties and candidates should behave during elections.

3 The ECI prepares the voters' list, which includes the names of all eligible voters.



4 The ECI allocates symbols to candidates to contest elections.

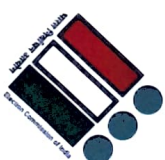


5 The ECI issues an electoral photo identity card or voter's identity card to all eligible voters.



KEYWORDS

autonomous body: an independent body or institution that has the right and power to establish its own laws and code of conduct



State Election Commission

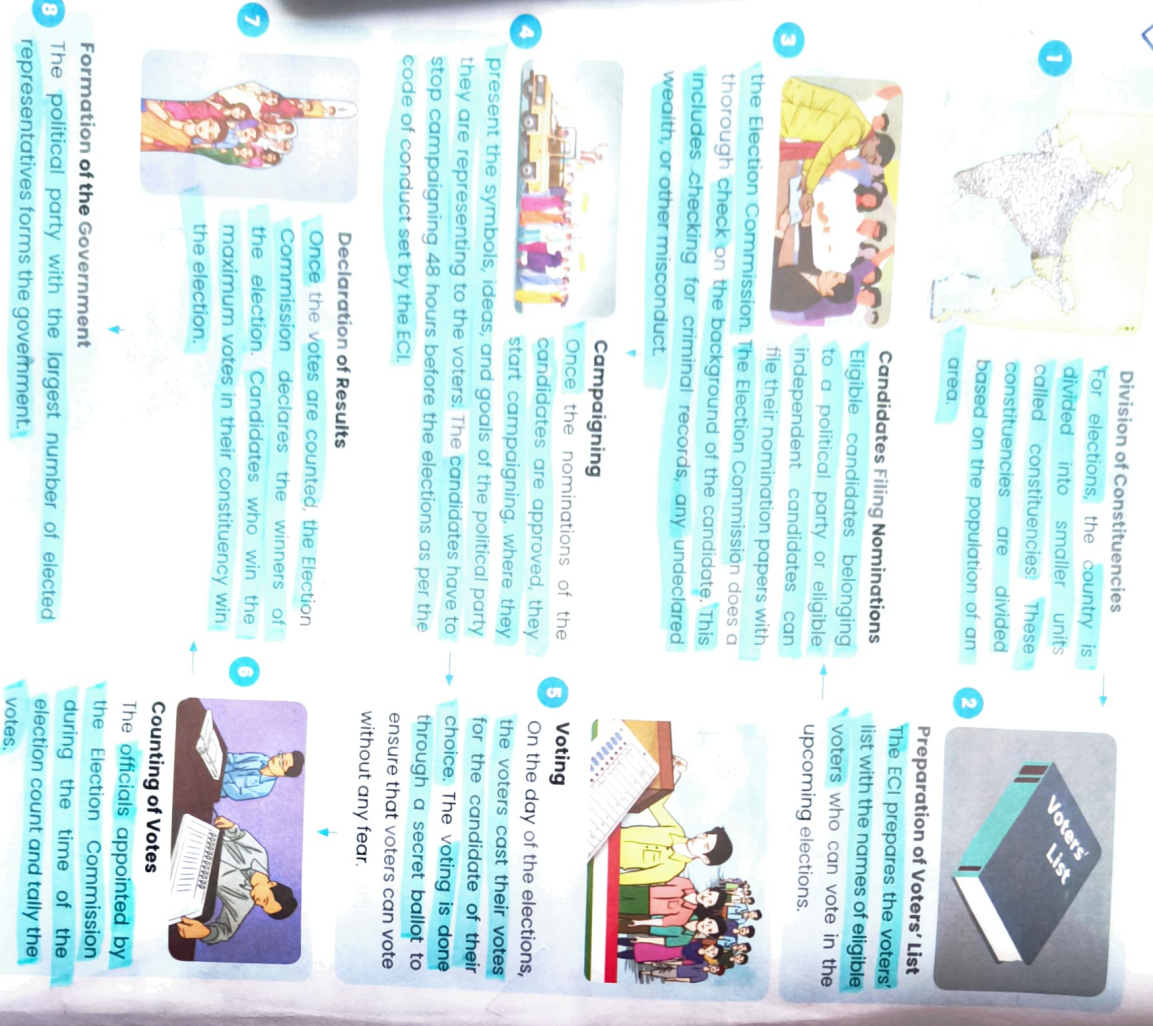
The State Election Commission is responsible for conducting free, fair, and impartial elections to the local bodies in the state. These include panchayats, municipalities, and corporations. The State Election Commission is headed by the State Election Commissioner. It performs a similar role as that of the ECI within the state.



Fig. 14.3: Symbol of the State Election Commission of Uttar Pradesh

14.3 PROCESS OF ELECTIONS

Elections do not just happen in a single day or even in a month. There are several steps involved in elections which must be followed over a period of time.



From Paper Ballots to EVMs

In the process of elections, we learned that voters use a secret ballot. How are these ballots cast? In school elections, you may use bits of paper. Earlier, the process of voting happened through paper ballots as well. Nowadays, in India, the Election Commission uses Electronic Voting Machines (EVMs).

Paper Ballot

Voters tick or put a stamp against the name of the candidate of their choice and insert the paper in the ballot.

Electronic Voting Machine

Voters select or click the blue button against the name and symbol of the candidate of their choice.

Both types of ballots have advantages and disadvantages.

Type of Ballot	Paper Ballot	Electronic Voting Machine (EVM)
Advantages	- A paper ballot cannot be tampered with using the internet. - The chances of malfunctioning are also minimal.	An EVM can be connected to a control unit, which allows the easy counting of votes.
Disadvantages	- The counting of votes takes hours or days as the officials must count each and every ballot. - Paper ballots can also get misplaced or lost.	While it is not proven, certain political parties claim that the EVMs can be manipulated using the internet.

To resolve the issue of manipulation of votes in EVMs, the ECI has introduced the Voter Verifiable Paper Audit Trail or VVPAT machine. When a voter clicks on the button next to their preferred candidate on the EVM, a slip showing the party symbol and the image of the candidates gets printed, which is visible to the voter.



Fig. 14.4: A VVPAT machine

THINK

Is VVPAT enough for free and fair elections in India? What are some other ideas that you have to make elections as free and fair as possible? List 2-3 ideas. Then, research on the internet about the practices followed by other countries and jot them down in your notebook. See if any of your ideas are being practised in other places.

DID YOU KNOW?

The Election Commission of India makes sure every voter can vote. They set up polling stations in very remote and hard-to-reach places, such as deep forests and mountaintops.



14.4 POLITICAL PARTIES

We learned that during the election process, candidates from different political parties file nominations and contest elections. A **political party** is a group of people who share a common ideology. Political parties select candidates from their members to contest elections. The party members agree on certain programmes and policies that will help in the smooth functioning of the country.

Types of Political Parties in India

During election campaigns, you might have seen candidates from several political parties contesting against each other. They either belong to a national party or a state or regional party. This classification is based on the recognition given by the ECI.

1. National Parties

- They are present and function across the country in several states.
- They focus on issues related to the country.
- Examples: Indian National Congress (INC) and Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP)

2. State Parties

- They are present and function in a particular region or state.
- They focus on issues related to the region or state.
- They are also known as regional parties.
- Examples: Shiv Sena, Biju Janata Dal (BJD), and Asom Gana Parishad (AGP)

3. Registered but Unrecognised Parties

- There are some political parties that are registered with the ECI that do not meet the criteria for recognition. Such political parties are called 'registered but unrecognised parties'.
- These parties can also contest elections. However, they do not have an election symbol of their own.
- They can choose one symbol from the free symbol poll panel (list of symbols that do not belong to any other political party) provided by the ECI to contest elections.

Given below are some examples of both national and state parties.

Party	Symbol
Bahujan Samaj Party (BSP)	
Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP)	
Communist Party of India (Marxist) (CPI(M))	
Indian National Congress (INC)	
National People's Party (NPP)	
Asom Aomni Party (AAP)	

KEYWORDS

ideology: a set of beliefs
policies: a set of ideas or plans

CONNECT TO LIFE

Have you seen candidates from different political parties campaigning before elections? What do they discuss in their speeches?

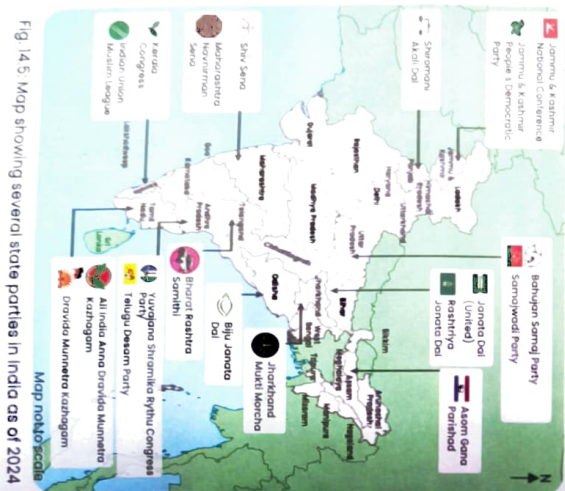


Fig. 14.5: Map showing several state parties in India as of 2024

Ruling, Minority, and Opposition Parties

All types of political parties participate in the elections. Based on the number of seats they win, they are called the ruling party, the minority party, or the opposition party. We will understand this using the example of the elections held to choose the central government.

Ruling Party

The party that wins the largest number of seats is called the ruling or majority party. The ruling party generally forms the government.

Opposition Party

The parties that do not form the government are called opposition parties. The party that wins the second-highest number of seats is called the **major opposition party**. The leader of the opposition is generally elected from this party.

Minority Party

Parties with a small number of elected candidates are called minority parties.



A party must win more than half the number of seats in the elections to form the central government. Using the example in the image above, the total number of elected seats in the Lok Sabha is 543. A party must win at least 272 seats (over half of 543) to form the government. Here, the political party represented by the pink dots will form the government.

However, what happens if no party wins 272 seats? Will there be no ruling party? In such cases, **political parties can come together to form a coalition**. For example, if Party A won 269 seats, Party B won 142 seats, Party C won 96 seats, and Party D won 36 seats, then Parties B, C, and D can come together to form a coalition. Their total votes would add up to 274, which is a simple majority. The government formed in such a manner is called a coalition government.

Role of the Opposition Party

Let us learn about the important roles the opposition party plays in the government.

1. It questions the government about policies it has made to ensure they benefit the citizens.
2. It makes sure that the government is not **autocratic** and that its power remains in check.
3. It acts as a voice of the citizens against policies that are unacceptable or unpopular.
4. It brings up the issues or problems that are not being addressed by the government.

Party Systems

Political parties function differently across countries. The way in which political parties function in a country is called a **party system**.

KEYWORDS

autocratic: controlled by one person who makes decisions without taking any advice or input from others



Fig. 14.6: A representation of a member of an opposition party questioning the government policies

Types of Party Systems

1. Single-Party System



- Under a single-party system, only one political party can form the government by law, even though other political parties might exist. One party controls all decision-making, and citizens have limited rights.

- Examples of countries that follow this party system: North Korea, Cuba, and China

2. Bi-Party System



- Under a bi-party system, many political parties can exist, but there are two main political parties. Out of these two parties, the party with the greater number of representatives forms the majority, and the other forms the minority.

- Examples of countries that follow this party system: the USA and the UK

3. Multi-Party System



- Under a multi-party system, several political parties contest elections. The party that wins the most seats forms the government alone, or several parties can form a coalition to form the government.

- Examples of countries that follow this party system: India, France, Sweden, and Norway

Impact of Political Parties on Society

4-5

Political parties impact society in the following ways:

- They bring people with similar ideas and opinions together.
- They bring about changes that are desired by the people.
- They make sure that the voices of the citizens are heard.
- They ensure that the government keeps its promises.
- They educate people on major social issues, such as educating children and raising awareness about the importance of drinking clean water.

COMMUNICATE

Create your own political party. Create a name for your party and draw a symbol for it in your notebook. Then, on an A4 sheet, prepare a presentation introducing your party. Write the name, draw the symbol, and explain the goals of your party. Be prepared to present in class.

LET'S REVISE

Elections

The process through which citizens choose their representatives in the government



Types of Elections

- General elections** – conducted every five years
- Midterm elections** – conducted when the ruling government does not complete its term
- By-elections** – conducted when an elected representative passes away or resigns before their term ends

- How are free and fair elections conducted?**
- All citizens who are 18 years of age or older are eligible to vote in elections.
- One person has only one vote.
- Each voter has the freedom to vote for the candidate of their choice without fear.

Election Commission of India

It is an autonomous body responsible for conducting free and fair elections in India. It has the following functions:

- Providing a code of conduct for elections
- Preparing voters' list and issuing voter ID cards to eligible voters
- Allocating symbols to candidates

Process of Elections

- Division of constituencies
- Preparation of voters' list
- Candidates filing nominations
- Campaigning
- Voting
- Counting of votes
- Declaration of results
- Formation of the government

Political Party

A group of people who share a common ideology

Types of Political Parties

Based on region

- National parties
- State or regional parties
- Registered but unrecognised parties

Based on election results

- Ruling party
- Opposition party
- Minority party
- Single-party system
Examples: China and North Korea
- Bi-party system
Examples: the USA and the UK
- Multi-party system
Examples: India, France, and Sweden

Party Systems

EXERCISES

A. Fill in the blanks.

- The territory of India is an autonomous body responsible for conducting free and fair elections in India.
- For elections, the country is divided into smaller units called constituencies.
- Candidates start campaigning before elections in which they try to convince voters that they are right for the job.
- Political parties are a group of people who believe in a common ideology.
- India follows a multi-party system.

B. Choose the correct answer.

- Which of the following is NOT a type of election in India?
 - General elections
 - Annual elections
 - Midterm elections
 - By-elections
- Which of the following is NOT a role performed by the Election Commission of India?
 - Conducting free and fair elections
 - Preparing a voters' list
 - Issuing voter's identity card
 - Campaigning
- Which of the following is NOT a type of political party present in India?
 - State party
 - National party
 - International party
 - Registered but unrecognised party
- Which party makes sure that the government is not autocratic and that its power remains in check?
 - Minority party
 - Opposition party
 - Ruling party
 - National party

5. Which party system exists in countries such as North Korea, Cuba, and China?

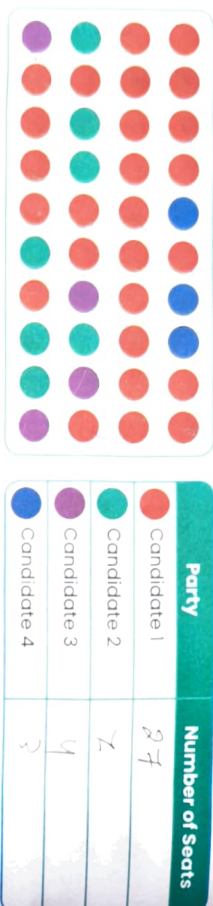
- (a) Multi-party system
(b) Bi-party system
(c) Both (a) and (b)
(d) Single-party system

C. Write True or False. Rewrite the false statements correctly in your notebook.

- General elections in India are held once every seven years. *True*
- The Election Commission of India allocates symbols to candidates to contest elections. *True*
- The officials appointed by the political parties count and tally the votes. *False*
- State parties are some political parties that are registered with the ECI but do not meet the criteria for recognition.
- The minority party forms the government.

D. The image below shows election results in a constituency. Look at the image carefully, and answer the questions that follow.

1. Fill the table with the number of votes each candidate has won.



2. Which candidate has won in this constituency? Give a reason to support your answer.

E. Answer the following questions in brief:

- Explain why elections are important in not more than 40 words.
- Define free and fair elections.
- What are the benefits of using EVMs over ballot papers?
- What is the role of the opposition party in the government?
- Explain the party system that China follows in not more than 50 words.

F. Answer the following questions in detail:

- Explain the three types of elections conducted in India.
in below in page 195 pg.
 - The Election Commission of India is responsible for conducting free and fair elections in India.
in below in page 195 pg.
 - Explain this statement with reasons.
 - Explain the process of elections in India in about 80 words.
 - Explain the types of political parties in India. Give two examples for each.
 - Why are political parties necessary in a democracy like India? *for the better nation*
- (Writing tip: Start your answer with the phrase 'Political parties are necessary in a democracy like India because...')

G. HOTS — Think and answer.

1. Which party system do you think works best for a democracy? Why do you think so?

2. Read the imaginary election results given below and answer the following questions in your notebook:

Party	Seats Won	Party	Seats Won
Party A	50	Party A	60
Party B	38	Party B	75
Party C	5	Party C	3
Total Seats	93	Total Seats	138

- (i) Who will form the government?
(ii) Who will form the opposition?

H. Competency-based questions

1. Your neighbourhood is preparing for local elections. You notice colourful posters of different candidates all over the streets, and some candidates are using loudspeakers to announce their promises.

- (a) What is this pre-election activity called? *campaigning*
(b) Why do candidates engage in this activity before elections?
(c) According to election rules, when must candidates stop this activity? *at the time before*

2. Read the article given below and answer the questions that follow.

Daily News

Elections Cancelled in the Vellore District of Tamil Nadu

17 April 2019

The Lok Sabha election to the Vellore constituency in Tamil Nadu was cancelled on Tuesday after ECI officials found that the candidate used money to influence voters. This has not been an isolated incident; many such events have taken place over the years. The growing greed for power has turned an important process in democracy into a show of money and power.



- (a) Why were the elections cancelled?
(b) Had the election not been cancelled, do you think it would be a free and fair one? Why or why not?
(c) How would the ECI ensure that the next election is free and fair?

REFLECTIONS

- What is something new you learned about democracy in this chapter?
- What is one question you would ask a politician who is campaigning in your area?
- What is one thing you want a political party to do once they come to power?